

DIVERSE PERSPECTIVES ON THE STATE

UPSC PRELIMS + GS MAINS | PRIMARY HOME: GS-II CONCEPTUAL FOUNDATIONS

Continuous core-first rail | Advanced enrichment stays subordinate to the GS core

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ORIGIN AND DATED RAIL

1588-1679	Theory Thomas Hobbes
1632-1704	John Locke
1690	In his Two Treatises of Civil Government
1711-76	David Hume
1712-78	Jean Jacques Rousseau
1723-90	Adam Smith
1724-1804	Immanuel Kant
1729-97	Edmund Burke
1737-1809	Tom Paine
1748-1832	Jeremy Bentham
1755	Rousseau Rousseau, in his Discourse on Inequality
1762	However, in his later work The Social Contract
1773-1836	James Mill
1776	Inquiry into the Nature and Causes of the Wealth of Nations
1789	French Revolution
1806-73	John Stuart Mill
1806-73	LIBERALISM John Stuart Mill
1814-76	Mikhail Bakunin
1818-83	Karl Marx
1818-83	Marx Like Marx
1820-1903	Herbert Spencer
1820-95	Friedrich Engels
MECHANISM	Chronology fixes what each named work actually changed, so the argument cannot slide into a vague rise-and-fall story.
TRAP / LIMIT	"Organic theory simply means patriotism." -> In Gauba it is a strong claim that the state is natural, ethically prior and superior to the individual (PDF pp.221-223)
ANSWER LINE	natural growth / contract / class division / colonial history / associations

2

CHAPTER SPINE, STEP BY STEP

- Gauba begins by saying the aim is to bring out the complexity of the problem, not to pronounce any final verdict on the state (PDF p.220)
- The organic view treats the state as natural and ethical, with individual freedom realized through obedience and functional differentiation (PDF pp.221-225)
- The liberal-individualist stream treats the state as artificial, but it branches into contractarian legitimacy, laissez-faire protection, and later welfare revision (PDF pp.226-260)

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- The liberal-individualist stream treats the state as artificial, but it branches into contractarian legitimacy, laissez-faire protection, and later welfare revision (PDF pp.226-260)
- Marxism rejects both organic and liberal harmony and sees the state as an instrument of class domination and class exploitation (PDF pp.261-266)
- Communitarianism attacks the liberal image of the detached self and wants the political order to cultivate common goods and shared identities (PDF pp.267-270)
- Post-colonial analysis adds the historical burdens of colonial rule, inherited bureaucracy, nation-building and neo-colonial continuities (PDF pp.270-273)
- Gandhian thought morally distrusts the coercive state and shifts the ideal toward self-rule, trusteeship, bread labour and village-centred democracy (PDF pp.273-277)
- Feminist and pluralist perspectives then challenge the state from two further sides: gendered power and dispersed associational power (PDF pp.277-279)

MECHANISM The spine is the order in which the source itself develops the argument; reproducing it keeps the answer sequenced rather than listed.

TRAP / LIMIT "All contract theorists defend limited government." -> Hobbes does not; Locke does; Rousseau is popular-sovereign but still absolutist in an important sense (PDF pp.230-234)

ANSWER LINE Organic theory: the state is like an organism; individuals are like its organs, and their worth depends on the whole (PDF pp.221-223)

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ILLUSTRATIONS ATTACHED TO THE CLAIMS THEY SUPPORT

The Nazi and Fascist experiences are used by Gauba as

The Nazi and Fascist experiences are used by Gauba as historical warnings against treating state authority as absolute and beyond challenge (PDF p.224)

Locke's defence of the Glorious Revolution of 1688 is a

Locke's defence of the Glorious Revolution of 1688 is a historical example of limited government and a right to replace rulers who betray the trust (PDF p.232). Dating/framing caution: Locke's Two Treatises of Government was published in 1689 (title page dated 1690), and is popularly taught as a direct, after-the-fact justification of 1688. Peter Laslett's textual scholarship established that most of the work was actually composed earlier, c. 1679-1683, during the Exclusion Crisis, likely to justify resistance to Charles II/James II's succession rather than to celebrate an event that had not yet occurred. The safer exam framing is: Locke's argument for trust, limited government and a right to resist a government that breaches that trust was available before 1688 and was then read publicly as the philosophical defence of the Revolution Settlement once it was published - not that Locke sat down in 1689 to write an apologia for a completed revolution. Use "associated with," "came to justify," or "published shortly after and read as vindicating" rather than an unqualified "written to defend."

Gauba's account of nineteenth-century capitalism uses child

Gauba's account of nineteenth-century capitalism uses child labour, slum housing and harmful commodities as historical illustrations of why laissez-faire had to be revised (PDF pp.245-247)

Macaulay's 1835 educational minute and colonial

Macaulay's 1835 educational minute and colonial infrastructure in India are cited as historical illustrations of how colonial institutions could modernize and dominate at the same time (PDF pp.271-272)

Gandhi's swaraj discussion here prepares the conceptual

Gandhi's swaraj discussion here prepares the conceptual ground for the later civil-disobedience discussion in Political-Theory/basic/14_Political-Obligation-Resistance-and-Law.md

Solidarity in Poland and environmental groups in Eastern

Solidarity in Poland and environmental groups in Eastern Europe are book-period illustrations of associational pressure helping authoritarian systems give way to pluralist democracy (PDF p.278)

MECHANISM Examples are evidence only when the answer states what they prove and where they stop proving it.

TRAP / LIMIT "Liberalism always means minimal state." -> Gauba clearly distinguishes laissez-faire from welfare or positive liberalism (PDF pp.243-260)

ANSWER LINE Natural state vs artificial state: organic theory treats the state as a natural condition of civilized life, whereas liberal and Marxist theories treat it as historically produced or

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COMPARISON MATRIX

Perspective	State origin	State purpose	Liberty	Inequality	Civil society	Route to change
Organic / idealist	Natural or historical growth; state logically prior to the individual (PDF pp.221-223)	Secure good life and moral development (PDF pp.221-223)	Often equated with obedience to the state; critics reject this reduction (PDF pp.223-225)	Frequently treated as functional or natural hierarchy (PDF pp.222-225)	Tends to blur state and society (PDF p.224)	Organic growth and ethical cultivation, not contract or revolution
Social-contract	Artificial agreement out of the state of nature (PDF pp.226-236)	Security, order, rights-protection or civil liberty, depending on thinker (PDF pp.227-234)	Hobbes narrows liberty for security; Locke preserves rights; Rousseau transforms natural into civil liberty (PDF pp.228-234)	Formally begins from equality of contractors, but Gauba criticizes this simplification (PDF pp.235-236)	Often secondary to the constituted political order	Constitutional replacement or renewed consent, especially in Locke (PDF pp.231-232)
Laissez-faire liberal	Artificial and limited state; may emerge from contract or protection needs (PDF pp.236-244)	Protect life, property, contract and external order (PDF pp.236-244)	Negative liberty, market freedom and freedom from interference (PDF pp.236-244)	Accepts inequality if produced by free acquisition and exchange; Spencer radicalizes this (PDF pp.242-244)	Voluntary association and market society are primary	Reform by limiting state action, not redistributive transformation
Welfare / positive liberal	State still artificial/instrumental, but rooted in moral community and social interdependence (PDF pp.245-260)	Remove obstacles to self-development and secure welfare, education and social justice (PDF pp.250-260)	Positive liberty: real capacity to develop and act well (PDF pp.251-253)	Inequality is tolerable only if socially functional and checked by welfare and taxation; Gauba shows liberal debate here (PDF pp.250-257)	Society is morally prior to the state in Green and MacIver (PDF pp.252-260)	Incremental democratic reform, regulation and welfare expansion
Marxist / class	Arises with private property and class	In reality, preserve dominant-class rule	Liberal freedom is formal; real freedom	Inequality is structurally produced by	Civil society can reproduce hegemony	Revolution, proletarian rule in transition

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Marxist / class	Arises with private property and class division (PDF pp.261-263)	In reality, preserve dominant-class rule and suppress class conflict (PDF pp.262-266)	Liberal freedom is formal; real freedom needs class emancipation (PDF pp.262-266)	Inequality is structurally produced by ownership and exploitation (PDF pp.261-265)	Civil society can reproduce hegemony, especially in Gramsci (PDF pp.266-267)	Revolution, proletarian rule in transition, then withering away of the state (PDF pp.263-266)
Communitarian	Political order grows out of socially situated selves, not isolated individuals (PDF pp.267-270)	Sustain common good, shared identity and moral responsibility (PDF pp.268-270)	Liberty is meaningful only within a well-functioning community (PDF pp.267-270)	Worries less about abstract equality than about disintegration and misdistribution across social spheres (PDF pp.268-270)	Community, not mere association, is central (PDF pp.267-270)	Moral reconstruction of community and institutions
Post-colonial	Shaped by colonial conquest, inherited borders, elites and institutions (PDF pp.270-273)	Nation-building, state-building and developmental fulfilment after empire (PDF pp.272-273)	Freedom means more than formal independence; it includes decolonizing values and institutions (PDF pp.271-273)	Inequality is tied to colonial domination, dependence and internal fragmentation (PDF pp.270-273)	Civil society can be awakened by colonial education and national movement, but may also inherit elite bias (PDF pp.271-273)	Decolonization, nation-building and welfare extension
Gandhian	State emerges from coercive and centralized political power; ideal life points beyond it (PDF pp.273-277)	At best a temporary means; ideal is self-regulated swaraj (PDF pp.274-277)	Freedom is self-rule, self-discipline and capacity to resist abused authority (PDF pp.275-277)	Inequality is moral as well as economic; Gandhi answers it through dignity of labour and trusteeship (PDF pp.274-275)	Village community and moral society are higher than centralized rule (PDF pp.275-277)	Non-violent reform, self-purification and decentralized reconstruction
Feminist	Existing states are shaped within gendered power relations, not gender-neutral social contracts (PDF pp.277-278)	Secure justice against male violence, unequal power and exclusion (PDF pp.277-278)	Freedom includes bodily autonomy, reproductive choice and freedom from domination in both public and private life (PDF pp.277-278)	Gender hierarchy is structural, not accidental (PDF pp.277-278)	Family and intimacy are political sites, not extra-political zones (PDF p.277)	Legal reform, welfare claims and deeper transformation of patriarchal structures
Pluralist	Modern democracy produces multiple centres of power and association (PDF pp.278-279)	Coordinate, arbitrate and justify authority through justice across groups (PDF pp.278-279)	Freedom of association is indispensable (PDF p.278)	Early pluralism underestimated unequal bargaining power; Dahl and Lindblom later qualify this (PDF p.279)	Civil society is the bulwark of democratic order (PDF p.278)	Redistribution of power, stronger associations and democratic correction

MECHANISM	Running the comparison on shared axes converts a description into an adjudication.
TRAP / LIMIT	"Pluralism proves the state is neutral." -> Even Gauba's pluralist discussion admits unequal groups and privileged interests; neutrality remains contested (PDF p.279)
ANSWER LINE	Aristotle: the state exists for life and continues for the good life; man is intelligible as a political being only within the polis (PDF pp.221-222)

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EXAMINER TRAP FIREWALL

TRAP	"Organic theory simply means patriotism."
REPAIR	In Gauba it is a strong claim that the state is natural, ethically prior and superior to the individual (PDF pp.221-223)
TRAP	"All contract theorists defend limited government."
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TRAP	"Gandhi was just another anarchist."
REPAIR	Gandhi shares suspicion of coercive authority, but grounds his position in ahimsa, religion, swaraj and satyagraha, not in the same premises as Bakunin or Kropotkin (PDF pp.274-277)
TRAP	"Feminism studies only representation in parliament."
REPAIR	Gauba's feminist section insists that domination extends into intimate relations and that the personal itself is political (PDF p.277)
TRAP	"Miliband and Poulantzas say the same thing about the capitalist state."
REPAIR	Miliband's instrumentalism (state = direct tool of capitalist class via personnel/economic power/vested interest) is explicitly rejected by Poulantzas's structuralism (relative autonomy of the state, legitimacy through "the people," state as arena of class struggle); Gauba himself flags the risk that Poulantzas's autonomy thesis can drift away from core Marxism (PDF p.266)
TRAP	"Locke wrote the Two Treatises after 1688 specifically to celebrate the Glorious Revolution."
REPAIR	Laslett's scholarship shows most of the text was composed c.1679-1683, before the Revolution; it was published in 1689 and then read as the Revolution's philosophical defence - composition predates the event popularly said to have inspired it
TRAP	"Millett and Eisenstein make the identical feminist argument about the state."
REPAIR	Millett's entry point is the personal/intimate sphere and "power-structured relationships"; Eisenstein's is the liberal state's claimed neutrality and its socialist-feminist critique of capitalist welfare policy - distinct emphases within one broader feminist perspective (PDF pp.277-278)
MECHANISM	Each pair is a tested misreading followed by the exact repair the source supports.
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ANSWER LINE	MacIntyre, Sandel, Walzer, Taylor: they criticize the atomistic liberal self and recover community, embeddedness and differentiated spheres of justice (PDF pp.267-270)

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OWNERSHIP BOUNDARIES AND CROSS-LINKS

THIS TOPIC OWNS - Use Political-Theory/advanced/13_Diverse-Perspectives-on-the-State.md for the full direct-book reconstruction and the larger comparative argument - Use Political-Theory/basic/10_State-Civil-Society-Nation-and-Internationalism.md before this file if you need the basic distinction between state, government, society and civil society - Use Political-Theory/basic/11_Sovereignty-and-Pluralism.md and Political-Theory/basic/12_Globalisation-and-Challenges-to-Sovereignty.md to connect state theory with sovereignty and global pressures - Use Political-Theory/basic/05_Socialism-Fascism-Anarchism-and-Gandhism.md, Political-Theory/basic/06_Feminism-Sex-and-Gender.md and Political-Theory/basic/07_Nature-of-Politics-and-Communitarianism.md for ideology-specific foundations already studied separately - Use Philosophy/paper-2/socio-political/Individual-and-State.md, Philosophy/paper-2/socio-political/Caste-Gandhi-Ambedkar.md and Philosophy/paper-2/socio-political/Gender-Discrimination.md for Philosophy-optional parallels - Boundary: this file remains conceptual; it does not reproduce Indian constitutional articles, statutes or case law	
DELEGATED OR EXCLUDED - Direct constitutional, scheme and case facts	
MECHANISM	Syllabus boundary discipline prevents a conceptual answer from being marked down as off-topic.
TRAP / LIMIT	"Feminism studies only representation in parliament." -> Gauba's feminist section insists that domination extends into intimate relations and that the personal itself is political (PDF p.277)
ANSWER LINE	Perspective - State origin - State purpose - Liberty - Inequality - Civil society - Route to change

7

REVISION CAPSULE AND ANSWER SPINE

● Start with Gauba's caution: there is no final verdict on the state; different theories illuminate different aspects	
● Then classify the perspectives in three clusters: ethical-natural (organic), liberal-instrumental (contract, laissez-faire, welfare, pluralist), and critical-transformative (Marxist, communitarian, post-colonial, Gandhian, feminist)	
● Use the mandatory six tests in any answer: origin, purpose, liberty, inequality, civil society, route to change	
● Add one sentence that liberal neutrality is disputed by Marxist, feminist, post-colonial and pluralist critics	
● End with a balanced conclusion: the state can be read as protector, welfare agent, class instrument, coercive machine or coordinator depending on what dimension of power one foregrounds	
MECHANISM	The capsule is the last-minute recall rail; it should be reproducible in under two minutes.
TRAP / LIMIT	"Miliband and Poulantzas say the same thing about the capitalist state." -> Miliband's instrumentalism (state = direct tool of capitalist class via personnel/economic power/vested interest) is explicitly rejected by Poulantzas's structuralism (relative autonomy of the state, legitimacy through "the people," state as arena of class struggle); Gauba himself flags the risk that Poulantzas's autonomy thesis can drift away from core Marxism (PDF p.266)
ANSWER LINE	"Organic theory simply means patriotism." -> In Gauba it is a strong claim that the state is natural, ethically prior and superior to the individual (PDF pp.221-223)

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GS MAINS QUESTION ROUTES CARRIED BY THIS TOPIC

10-mark route Compare the organic and social-contract perspectives on the origin and purpose of the state. Answer in 150 words	10-mark route Distinguish the laissez-faire state from the welfare or positive-liberal state. Answer in 150 words
10-mark route Critically examine the Marxist theory of the state with reference to Miliband and Poulantzas. Answer in 150 words	15-mark route Compare Gandhian and pluralist criticisms of centralised state power. Answer in 250 words
15-mark route Evaluate diverse perspectives on the state through origin, purpose, liberty, inequality, civil society and route to change. Answer in 250 words	15-mark route How do feminist and post-colonial perspectives widen classical state theory? Answer in 250 words
MECHANISM	Directive fidelity, not content volume, decides the band a Mains answer lands in.
TRAP / LIMIT	"Locke wrote the Two Treatises after 1688 specifically to celebrate the Glorious Revolution." -> Laslett's scholarship shows most of the text was composed c.1679-1683, before the Revolution; it was published in 1689 and then read as the Revolution's philosophical defence - composition predates the event popularly said to have inspired it
ANSWER LINE	Directive - What it demands - Trap to avoid

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QUALIFIED VERDICT

Natural state vs artificial state: organic theory treats the state as a natural condition of civilized life, whereas liberal and Marxist theories treat it as historically produced or MacIntyre, Sandel, Walzer, Taylor: they criticize the atomistic liberal self and recover community, embeddedness and differentiated spheres of justice (PDF pp. 267-270).